

cent), Tamil (38.9 per cent), Punjabi (38.2 per cent) and Marathi (39.3 per cent), among the languages of South Asia.

So how did it all start?

Let's hear the story in Goyal's words: "calibre started life on October 31, 2006, soon after the release of the Sony PRS-500, the first e-ink based reader to be sold commercially in the US."

At the time, Goyal was a graduate student with a lot of time on his hands. And, the PRS-500 did not work at all with GNU/Linux, his operating system of choice. So he decided to reverse engineer the USB protocol that it used, to get it working on FOSS (free and open source software).

"This was accomplished with the help of the fine folks over at *mobileread.com* and calibre was born, albeit named *libprs500*. Since *libprs500* seemed to have a fair number of fans, I decided to put up a small 'Donate' button on its website," Goyal told *OpenSource* magazine in an interview.

And then what?

Goyal continues reminiscing, "In the initial stages, it created enough income for me to afford one pizza a week, which was very welcome as a grad student. As the book phenomenon took off, that income grew and *libprs500* usage also started shooting through the roof."

Wow!

So Goyal began to seriously consider doing this on a full-time basis. It was when he returned home to India — he's based in Mumbai — to get married, that he renamed *libprs500* to calibre and decided to "get more serious about doing it full time."

"It was still very much a leap into the unknown for me, as I had always envisaged a career as an academic before then. But, with the support of my wife and with my fingers very much crossed, after graduating, I took the plunge and have never looked back since. The calibre community



Kovid Goyal, Calibre

has supported me working on it full time, ever since," he told this magazine, with a clear sense of accomplishment.

So, what would he rate as calibre's unique contribution to the brave new world of e-books, a phenomenon which is hardly over a decade old?

"Most of calibre's major features are unique to it," Kovid points out. calibre is described as "a powerful and easy-to-use e-book manager." It's a tool that will "allow you to do nearly everything and it takes things a step beyond normal e-book software. It's also completely free and open source, and great for both casual users and computer experts."

It promises a lot — saving of time while managing your e-book collection, the ability to "use it everywhere and with anything," a comprehensive e-book viewer, the possibility to download news and magazines from the Web, the option to back up and share your library easily, and a chance to even edit books in your collection. Along with all this comes the bonus of support.

With its versatile nature, calibre allows you to do a lot of thing with your e-books. You can sort and group e-books by their metadata fields. Metadata (which is used to identify

e-books) can be 'pulled' in from different book related sources, online. It is possible to search a calibre library using various fields — author, title or keywords.

You can 'sideload' e-books into your calibre library, or wirelessly sync your cloud storage service with an e-book reading device. Online content-sources can be 'harvested' and converted into e-books. There are also 'recipes', which are small programs written in Python-based, domain-specific languages.

In reply to a query, Goyal says: "calibre has no significant competitors. Most other e-book management software is tied to some proprietary e-book ecosystem or the other. And because calibre, being free and open source, dominated this space right from the beginning, it has no non-proprietary competition."

Usage statistics of calibre show that its top users are in Spain, the US, Germany, China and France. India, with a mere 1.6 per cent share of all users worldwide, stands at a fairly poor 15th position. Come on guys, we could do better.

"The places with the most calibre usage are those with the most mature e-book ecosystems/markets," says Goyal.

So what was the toughest part of creating this product? "Dealing with trolls," Goyal replies. "Creating anything in the Internet age, involves growing a very thick skin," he adds.

Commenting on calibre a decade ago, on November 2009, Kovid Goyal had called it a project with "a vibrant open source community with half a dozen developers and many, many testers and bug reporters." Today's list of contributors to the project is very international.

Goyal looks back with justifiable pride, saying, "It is used in over 200 countries and has been translated into a dozen different languages by volunteers. calibre has become a